Student 001 — Research Proposal

Anonymized demo document • practice-led creative arts PhD concept

WORKING TITLE

Illustration as a Participatory Tool for Community Wellbeing and Social Expression

CONTEXT

This practice-led project examines how illustration, material experimentation and participatory visual methods can help communities articulate experiences that are difficult to express through conventional verbal formats. It sits between illustration research, socially engaged art and community-oriented creative practice.

RESEARCH QUESTIONS

How can illustration operate as a participatory rather than purely representational practice? How do material choices affect participation, emotional distance and accessibility? How can public-facing outputs preserve ambiguity while still supporting dialogue around wellbeing, identity and belonging?

METHODS

The project combines studio experimentation, co-design workshops, visual elicitation, reflective field notes, participant feedback and iterative public presentation. Outputs may include illustrated narratives, ceramic or textile objects, temporary installations and small-scale public interventions.

CONTRIBUTION

The research aims to develop a transferable practice framework for socially engaged illustration that connects visual narrative, materiality and participatory ethics. It also investigates how creative outputs can act as research evidence rather than decoration around a written thesis.

FIT AND SUPERVISION

The proposal is intentionally adaptable across art therapy, material practice, public art, visual narrative and creative-technology supervision contexts represented in the SmartMail demo roster.

PROVISIONAL TIMELINE

- Year 1 — literature/context review, ethics, studio pilots and method development.
- Year 2 — participatory fieldwork, iterative making and exhibition experiments.
- Year 3 — synthesis, final body of work, exegesis writing and dissemination.